BACK TO THE OLD GUARD



Congress leader **Rahul Gandhi** met party veteran **A.K. Antony** at his Thiruvananthapuram home on July 18, marking their first meeting since the latter left Delhi for Kerala in 2022. The interaction signals the Congress's renewed outreach to the old guard ahead of the 2026 assembly election. Antony may not be keeping well, but he still has influence among the coastal Latin Catholic community and could be a counter to the dissenting Shashi Tharoor.



Cultural Cosplay

The BJP is doing all it can to blend in with Bengal's culture. At a Durgapur rally on July 18, PM Modi ditched his usual "Jai Shri Ram" for chants of "Kali" and "Durga". Local BJP MLA Lakshman Ghorui's invites also mentioned only the two goddesses, though he misspelled 'Durga'. But then, this isn't the party's first cultural fumble. Ahead of the 2021 polls, they botched up Tagore's birthplace, mispronounced Bangla words, and tried to turn *bhadralok* into a marketing gimmick. Naming **Samik Bhattacharya** the new state unit chief seems like another attempt to court Bengal's elusive elite.



PROBLEM OF PLENTY

Punjab now has 20 officers of DGP (Director General of Police) rank, a record for any state. Eight IPS officers were promoted in July alone, many into 'special DGP' roles that carry prestige but often no real command. Ironically, the man heading the state force, Gaurav Yadav, is also just an officiating DGP. As one officer quipped, "We might need a DGP to manage the DGPs."



Kaushik Deka with Rahul Noronha, Avaneesh Misra, Jeemon Jacob, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar and Anilesh S. Mahajan

ECO WATCH

By **Jumana Shah**

DOLPHINS BEACHED, KERALA FRETS



In Kerala, dolphin carcasses are increasingly washing up ashore, with 18 reported in 2024 and four in 2025 so far, possibly linked to the cargo vessel carrying hazardous material sinking off Alappuzha. Most carcasses are of Indo-Pacific humpback dolphins, protected under the Indian Wildlife Act. Experts attribute the rise to increased reporting, intensive fishing, underwater noise pollution and vessel interactions. Rough seas in the monsoon disrupt dolphin communication, increasing vessel strikes. Autopsies have been conducted to determine cause of death, which include vessel strikes, bycatch (caught unintentionally), disease and pollution. Project Dolphin, launched in 2020, had stressed on conservation efforts focusing on a marine-specific approach, balancing fishermen's livelihoods and scientific involvement.

A WARBLER SINGS AGAIN

In the rugged Suru Valley of Ladakh, a team of five birders—Lt Gen. Bhupesh Goyal, Manjula Desai, Rigzin Nubu, Irfan Jeelani and Harish Thangaraj—achieved a historic feat on July 15, 2025. They spotted the Long-billed Bush Warbler (*Locustella major*), a near-extinct species not seen in India since 1979. Guided by its insect-like call, the team found the bird in dense willow thickets at 3,200 metres, a record altitude. The expedition, inspired by James Eaton's 2022 sighting in Gilgit-Baltistan, scoured historical data and satellite imagery to pin down possible habitats. A common sight in Ladakh till the 1920s, the warbler's disappearance was linked to habitat loss from agricultural expansion. The rediscovery was celebrated across the ornithologist community, and with renewed birder interest, more could be uncovered about the Himalayan range of this elusive species.

